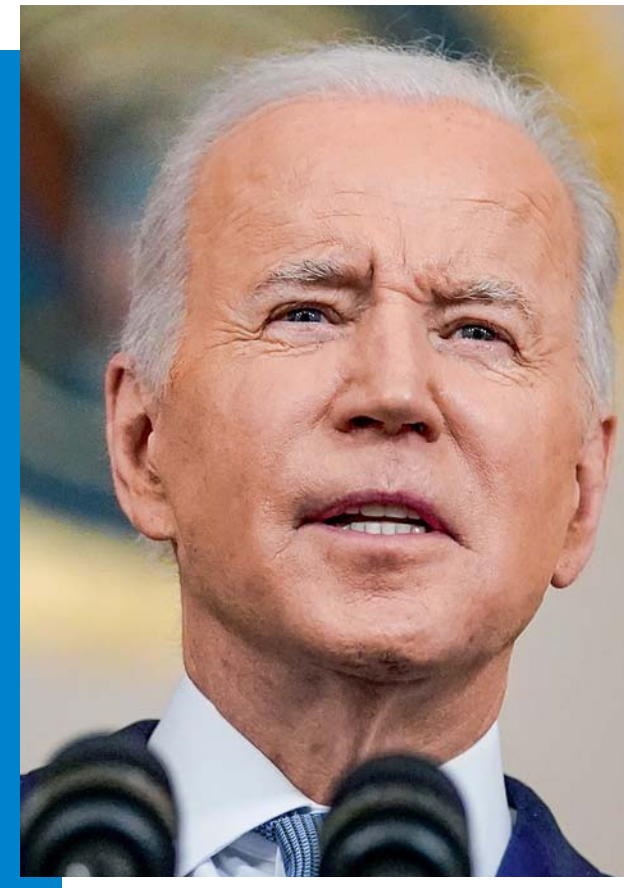
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HOMER'S EPIC *ODYSSEY*, Ulysses, the legendary Greek king, while journeying on the Mediterranean, found himself caught between Scylla and Charybdis, two mythical sea monsters that inhabited the opposite shores of the Strait of Messina near Italy. He was advised to lose a few sailors to Scylla rather than surrender his ship and entire crew to the more-feared Charybdis. Aeons later, Russian president Vladimir Putin believed he was confronting a Ulyssean dilemma. A creeping effort by countries allied to the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO) to encircle Russia—a containment strategy unfolding over a span of three decades—posed an existential threat to his once-great nation. His choices? Either wage war on Ukraine, Russia's immediate neighbour, which was keen to join the western alliance, or swallow the affront and watch Russia being treated as a pygmy in the emerging new world order.

Putin chose what he thought was the lesser of the two evils—subdue Ukraine before the western powers subdued Russia. Italian strategist Niccolo Machiavelli would have advised the same—"There is no avoiding war; it can only be postponed to the advantage of others." So, on February 24, the Russian president launched a full-scale invasion of Ukraine, setting in motion the largest-ever land battle waged in Europe since World War II. As Russia's massive armoured assault enters its second week, Putin's motive becomes increasingly clear—total subjugation of Ukraine,